

EHS Risk Assessment – Forensic Research Project

To be completed for each Undergraduate Teaching Subject.

Project Name: Developing a Methodological Framework for Investigating Online Extremism Communities on the Clear Web	
Students involved in assessment: Undisclosed	
Practical Date and Time: Friday, 1pm	Date of assessment:

Does this project possess any of the EHS hazards listed below in step 2 ?

- ☐ YES → complete this form.
☐ NO → simply skip to step 6 and sign the declaration.

STEP 1: DESCRIBE THE HAZARDOUS ACTIVITIES/TASKS IN THE PRACTICAL SESSION

Describe the tasks - list the methodology and briefly describe the steps involved in carrying out the prac work.

- Design and document a robust methodological approach for identifying relevant, clear-web platforms, acquiring publicly accessible data, and preparing it for analysis.
- Evaluate and compare tools and techniques for scraping, parsing, and structuring text-based online content.
- Produce a workflow demonstrating how digital traces from online communities can be collected and processed ethically and responsibly.
- Advise practitioners and researchers on effective strategies for identifying and accessing publicly available online content related to concerning or harmful communities.
- Provide recommendations on the tools, scripts, and workflows suitable for scraping and parsing online textual data.
- Demonstrate a reproducible digital acquisition and processing pipeline, including documentation of challenges, limitations, and ethical considerations.

STEP 2: IDENTIFY THE HAZARDS

a) Are you using... (Tick boxes ☒ where applicable – double click in box to check)

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ plant/equipment | ☐ imported biological material, cytotoxins, genetic manipulation ² |
| ☐ ionising radiation sources or equipment ^{2,3} | ☐ chemicals (hazardous substances/dangerous goods) ¹ |
| ☐ plug-in electrical appliances ² | ☐ sharps/needles |
| ☐ lifts/hoists/cranes ³ | ☐ pathogens/infectious materials ² |
| ☐ pressure vessels/boilers ³ | ☐ compressed gas |

b) Does the task involve... (Tick boxes ☒ where applicable – double click in box to check)

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ using tools/equipment with moving part(s) | ☐ clinical/industrial placement |
| ☐ using tools/equipment that vibrate | ☐ working at a height |
| ☐ electrical wiring ³ | ☐ working with lasers, microwaves or ultraviolet light |
| ☐ hazardous waste (biological or chemical) | ☐ working in isolation for extended periods |
| ☐ working with animals/insects | ☐ working in a confined space |
| ☐ working with fungi/bacteria/viruses | ☐ manual handling: repetitive or awkward movements |
| ☐ exposure to bodily fluids | ☐ manual handling: lifting or moving awkward or heavy objects |
| ☐ fieldwork ² | ☐ violent or volatile clients/interviewees |

c) Is there... (Tick boxes ☒ where applicable – double click in box to check)

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ noise ² | ☐ slippery surfaces/trip hazards |
| ☐ dust/fumes/vapours/gases | ☐ poor ventilation/air quality |
| ☐ extreme temperatures | ☐ a work area that is not suited for the task |
| ☐ a risk of fire/explosion | |
| ☐ other | |

¹ Specific risk assessment must be completed for hazardous substances and dangerous goods – see Step 3

² Specific control measures must be put in place for these hazards – see Step 3

³ Specific licences may be required for these hazards – see Step 3

STEP 3: EXISTING CONTROL MEASURES

a) Note strategies already in place to minimise the likelihood and/or severity of harm or loss.

- ☐ guarding/barriers
☐ biosafety cabinet
☐ fume cupboard/local exhaust ventilation
☐ lifting equipment/trolleys
☐ regular maintenance of equipment

☐ supervision
☐ training/information/instruction
☐ notes in laboratory/workshop manual or student handouts
☐ Personal Protective Equipment - gloves, boots, eye protection, hardhat, facemask, hearing protection, protective clothing

b) Note any specific risk assessments or licenses.

- ☐ chemical risk assessment (hazardous substances and dangerous goods)
☐ certification/licenses for operators of equipment
☐ test and tag plug-in electrical equipment

☐ monitor exposure levels (sound /substance/radiation)
☐ UTS Fieldwork Guidelines for overnight excursions in the field
☐ Biosafety Committee assessment for genetic manipulation, cytotoxins, pathogens, imported biological material, ionising radiation sources
☐ equipment licenses (pressure vessels, radiation equipment)

c) Note any emergency response systems.

- ☐ first aid kit
☐ chemical spill kit
☐ extended first aid kit
☐ evacuation/fire control

☐ safety shower
☐ eye wash station
☐ emergency stop button
☐ remote communication mechanism

☐ other risk control measures

STEP 4: ESTIMATED RISK LEVEL

Rate the level of risk, based on the **LIKELIHOOD** of harm or loss occurring and the **CONSEQUENCE** of that harm or loss, by marking the 'risk matrix' below. When doing this, consider:

- The harm or loss (to people, physical environment, or the University) that might be caused by the hazards listed, &
- The existing controls measures listed above

		CONSEQUENCE				
LIKELIHOOD		Insignificant	Minor	Moderate	Major	Catastrophic
	Almost certain	High	High	Extreme	Extreme	Extreme
	Likely	Medium	High	High	Extreme	Extreme
	Possible	Low	Medium	High	Extreme	Extreme
	Unlikely	Low	Low	Medium	High	Extreme
	Rare	Low	Low	Medium	High	High

For details on how to use this table, see <http://www.ehs.uts.edu.au/riskmgmt/rmprinciples.html#step2>

High Risk and **Extreme Risk** activities must not be carried out.

STEP 5: ACTION REQUIRED TO FURTHER CONTROL THE RISK

Are there any further actions required to reduce risk?

- ☐ **YES** ☐ **NO (Go to Step 6)**

If risk can be further reduced to a practicable level, then note further actions required. Base these on the priorities listed to the right. Also list any specific assessments required.

Refer to the example controls listed earlier. Also consider:

- Redesigning the workplace or activity
- Replacing the hazard with something less hazardous

1. Eliminate the hazard

2. Keep the hazard and people apart

3. Change work methods

4. Use personal protective equipment

Once the actions are complete, sign and date the form.

Further Actions Required	Date Completed	Signed

GENERAL RISK ASSESSMENT TEMPLATE

ACTIVITY	ASSOCIATED HAZARDS	INHERENT RISK - Harm that could occur from these hazards if controls fail or are not in place.	CONTROL MEASURES - Proposed Action to minimise risk to an acceptable level. Responsibility of Manager.	RESIDUAL RISK LEVEL (H,M,L) If high risk, then all that is 'reasonably practicable' must been done to manage risk.
Scraping sensitive information from websites	Scraping and downloading information that may not be permissible to be downloaded	Retaliation from websites or users who do not want their information to be downloaded (i.e. Doxing, leaking IP address)	Follow the 'robots.txt' file of the websites we are scraping and code this into the scrapers to not take information that is unwanted. Using virtual Machines for scraping as an extra layer of safety.	Low
Downloading Programs/Software	Downloading and running software that may contain viruses/malware/ransomware	Laptop/PC can be infected with malware which results in loss of important computer files, remote access trojan, passwords stolen, etc.	Download programs/files from trusted sources, use up to date anti-virus software, keep data backed up and don't download files from unknown sources/links.	Low
Retrieving information and data on social media posts	Constant exposure to sensitive and harmful content (e.g. hate speeches) on social media posts	Researchers can face potential psychological issues and mental health issues	Remain researching on content made to the public. Deciding and identifying a specific type of content (less intense) on social media posts for the project. Inform a trusted individual about the matter.	Low
Plugging in a charger	Exposed charger/power point	Being electrocuted because of exposed wires/connections.	Check the connections of the charger/port before plugging anything in. Ensure there are no exposed wires that can cause harm.	Low
Working on laptop	Typing and mouse usage for extended periods of time	Wrist strain or injury, as well as wrist and forearm tendonitis	Typing in small fast bursts every 15-45 minutes, with frequent 5-10 minutes breaks, including a range of wrist and forearm training/stretching.	Low
Sitting for extended periods of time	Poor neck and back posturing and positioning, unnatural body positioning and spinal compression	Neck and back strain, resulting in injury and permanent poor posturing,	Taking a break from sitting every 45 minutes to go on a walk. Using a standing desk periodically. Practicing sitting with good posture and placing device at eye level. Stretching and muscle strengthening training.	Low
Looking at a computer screen	Extensive hours working on the computer and laptop screens	Eye strain and temporary orbital loss	Take consistent breaks away from the computer and laptop screens to minimise eye damage from extensive wrist exposure	Low

Minimal movement for extensive period	Immobility for time periods,	Cardiovascular disease, type 2 diabetes, obesity, lung and colon cancer.	Take breaks every 45 minutes and go for 10–15-minute walks. Exercise regularly (2 times a week of high intensity, 5 times a week for low intensity)	Low
Working for long periods of time without nutrition and hydration	Neglecting nutrition/food and water for long periods of time	Malnutrition, starvation, headaches, migraines,	Bring water bottle and take frequent sips every 15 minutes, take breaks for food every 3-4 hours	Low
Working on faulty hardware or excessive use	The laptop overheating/combusting.	Burns caused to legs/arms	Ensuring the hardware is not being used for too long and has sufficient airflow. Using equipment that is known not to have issues.	Low

Assessment approval: I am satisfied that the risks are not significant or are adequately controlled and that the resources required will be provided.

Subject Coordinator		Date	
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STEP 6: ARE THE RISKS CONTROLLED? YES

To be signed when actions are completed as noted in Step 5.

Subject Coordinator name (please PRINT)	Date
Student names	Date
Suhaylah Binte Suandi, Ethan Bobins, Mihir Verma, Quinn Schutz, Zed Wilson, Harrison Watkins	27/02/26

Guidance notes for documenting General Risk Assessments

ACTIVITY

Describe here any hazardous activities related to the work area or operation.

ASSOCIATED HAZARDS

Plant & Equipment – noise, vibration, moving parts (crushing, friction, stab, cut, shear), pressure vessels, lifts/hoists/cranes, sharps

Manual Handling – repetitive movements, lifting awkwardly, lifting heavy objects

Work Environment – moving objects, extremes in temperature, isolation, work at height, allergies to animal bedding, dander and fluids

People – potentially violent or volatile clients/interviewees

Communicable Diseases – exposure to bodily fluids/infectious materials, animal bites and scratches,

Environmental – emissions to atmosphere, discharge to soil and water bodies (including stormwater run-off), nuisance noise & odour

Radiation (non-ionizing) – including lasers, microwaves or UV light

Electrical – plug-in equipment used in ‘hostile’ work environment, exposed conductors, high voltage equipment

Pathogens – dealings with pathogenic microorganisms such as bacteria, parasites, fungi or viruses

GMOs – dealings with genetically modified organisms

Cytotoxins – carcinogens, mutagens or teratogens

Radiation (ionizing) – ionizing radiation source such as radioactive substance or radionuclide, or irradiating apparatus

Chemical – hazardous substances, dangerous goods, fumes, dust, compressed gas

INHERENT RISK

Provide details of the harm that could be caused to people or the environment if something goes wrong. For example: inhalation of fumes, laceration, injury to back, infection, burns to skin or eyes. Think about what could happen if controls fail or are not in place.

CONTROL MEASURES

This is proposed action to reduce risk to an acceptable level. Apply the “Hierarchy of Controls”, listed below, when deciding the best control measure to apply. Control types closer the top of the list are preferable.

1. **ELIMINATE THE HAZARD.** For example: use a different less dangerous piece of equipment, fix faulty machinery, use safer materials or chemicals
2. **ISOLATE THE HAZARD FROM THE PEOPLE.** Separate people from the danger. For example: use shielding, use lifting equipment or trolleys, remove dust or fumes with exhaust system, lock-out machinery.
3. **CHANGE THE WAY THE JOB IS DONE.** For example: change work practices, provide training, information and signs, write work procedures.
4. **USE PERSONAL PROTECTIVE EQUIPMENT (PPE),** noting specific PPE is required for each job. For example: respirator, hearing protection, gloves. Training and information is required for the use of PPE.

RESIDUAL RISK LEVEL (H, M, L)

Estimate risk taking into account the way the activity is run and control measures put in place. The level of risk can be determined by combining consequence and likelihood using the risk matrix from below. Residual risk should be reduced to a level acceptable by management.

CONSEQUENCE OF HARM

This is how bad it will be if something does go wrong i.e. the number of people that could be harmed, the severity of injury.

INSIGNIFICANT – Non-injury incident. Minor effects on biological or physical environment.

MINOR – Injury or ill health requiring first aid. Moderate, short-term effects but not affecting ecosystem functions.

MODERATE – Injury or ill health requiring medical attention. Serious medium-term environmental effects.

MAJOR – Injury or ill health requiring hospital admission. Very serious long term impairment of ecosystem functions.

CATASTROPHIC – Fatality or permanent disabling injury. Very serious long term impairment of ecosystem functions.

LIKELIHOOD OF HARM

Chance of harm occurring is affected by the duration of the activity and its frequency; the number of people doing the activity and the level of exposure to the hazard.

RARE – Heard of something like this occurring elsewhere.

UNLIKELY – The event does occur somewhere from time to time.

POSSIBLE – The event might occur once in your career.

LIKELY – The event has occurred several times or more in your career.

ALMOST CERTAIN – The event will occur on an annual basis.

	CONSEQUENCES				
LIKELIHOOD ↓	Insignificant	Minor	Moderate	Major	Catastrophic
Almost certain	H	H	E	E	E
Likely	M	H	H	E	E
Possible	L	M	H	E	E
Unlikely	L	L	M	H	E
Rare	L	L	M	H	H

From AS/NZS 4360: Risk Management.